

across many European countries.

- In the **UK** until July 2012 video games had been regulated by the BBFC. They are now largely regulated by the **Video Standards Council (VSC)** applying the **PEGI** system (Pan European Game Information). The PEGI system can be discussed in terms of its process (age ratings as well as visual descriptors of content) and also its attempt to harmonise the protection of children across Europe.
- Consider the effectiveness of PEGI (possibly in comparison with the BBFC or the American ESRB system in terms of authority and compliance).
- The game was **classified** 18 by PEGI and this in itself may be a good area for discussion.

Consider the impact of digitally convergent media platforms on global production, distribution and circulation:

- It is significant that the *Assassin's Creed III: Liberation* **hand held game** could be linked to the full PS3 **console version** of the game (owning both versions would unlock additional game content). This use of **convergence** is relevant in terms of promotion/marketing and circulation.
- The **internet/Wi-Fi functionality** of the PS Vita allows users opportunities to download additional content (DLC) such as weapons, characters and “skins” or outfits. It also affords users the chance to engage in **multiplayer versions** of the game. These features promote gamer engagement and identification with the game.

Consider theoretical perspectives:

A level only:

Regulation – Sonia Livingstone and Peter Lunt

- Consider the impact of **convergence** and **diversification** in media on regulatory practices. New technology (in this case the convergent PS Vita with access to internet etc.) opens up new opportunities and arguably new risks that complicate regulation.
- Questions that might be discussed in relation to Livingstone and Lunt include:
 - » Should regulation be more flexible?
 - » Should industries self-regulate?
 - » Should individuals be empowered to make their own decisions?
 - » Should individuals be expected to develop ‘media literacy’ and make

informed decisions for themselves?

Cultural Industries – David Hesmondhalgh:

- Use Hesmondhalgh to explore the way in which cultural industry companies might attempt to **minimise risk and maximise audiences**.
- The game is part of an established **franchise** with a large **fan-base**. Producers are clearly attempting to harness the popularity of this franchise to encourage **sales** both of the game itself and the hand-held device the PS Vita.
- The video game industry offers many comparable examples of attempts to use **software** (games) to sell **hardware** (games systems and platforms).

PART 2: STARTING POINTS – Audiences

Social and Cultural Contexts:

Considering video games in relation to **gender issues** may be a useful way to explore them in terms of **social and cultural significance**. The representation of female characters, under-representation of women in video game development and an assumed minority of female video games players are areas that could be explored. This game has a **female protagonist** and it may be useful to consider whether she subverts or reinforces expectations of female characters in games and how audiences may **respond** to this.

Consider how producers target, attract, reach, address and potentially construct audiences:

There are many aspects of the game that are significant in relation to audience **targeting and construction**:

- » The game is for a **hand held device**. This may imply it is aimed at a more casual or mobile gamer (a discussion here about “on the go” gamers playing mobile games versus traditional console and PC gamers may be useful).
- » The game features a female protagonist. This is unusual in the franchise and may be considered in terms of **appealing to a different demographic** (possibly linked to the “on the go” gamers discussion above). The existence of a female protagonist may also be discussed in terms of constructing audiences by asking whether this game might offer a platform for female gamer identification.